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The Impact of Social Media on Children's Mental Health and Well-being

The invention of the internet and social media has shifted and revolutionized the way we live, communicate, and access information. However, as children increasingly become involved in the digital environment, concerns about the negative impact of the internet on their lives have gained prominence. Recently, there have been multiple accusations targeting Meta for “violating consumer protection laws by unfairly ensnaring children and deceiving users about the safety of its platforms“, based on a news article by the New York Times. So in this essay, I will be researching the recent suing of Mark Zuckerberg and other CEOs of famous companies like TikTok, Snapchat, etc, why they are being sued, and whether it is their responsibility or not.

The impact of social media has affected our lives for a long time, both in a good way and bad way. However, along with all the benefits it has, there are more and more problems coming, especially for kids recently. Even though they are young and suggested not to use social media, with the growth of electronic devices and social platforms, there is almost no way to prevent that from happening. Because of that, it is those companies’ responsibility to restrict the contents, control what kind of commercials and news they are providing. One example is from a 15-year-old Manhattan boy who died subway surfing. Zackery Nazario tragically passed away on February 20, 2023, while engaging in subway surfing on a Brooklyn-bound J train across the Williamsburg Bridge. The incident occurred when a low beam struck Zackery's head, causing him to fall between the subway cars and subsequently be run over by the train. Following Zackery's unfortunate demise, his mother discovered numerous videos on his social media

accounts depicting subway surfing. Additionally, she found an advertisement for a ski mask, commonly worn by individuals participating in subway surfing to conceal their identities. It became evident that Zackery was deliberately drawn into the world of social media, actively seeking and engaging with content promoting the perilous activity of subway surfing.

The internet provides a platform for communication and social interaction, but it also exposes children to the dark side of online behavior. Cyberbullying and online harassment have become issues that are out of control, causing significant emotional distress among young individuals. If they don't take action right away or try to find a way to solve the problem, it is necessary for them to be sued and they should no longer be allowed to provide those platforms to the world. This is an emergency problem. During the past few years, there have been concerns and criticisms regarding the impact of social media platforms, including Instagram and Facebook, on children's mental health and well-being. It is dangerous because children can be vulnerable to cyberbullying, harassment, and peer pressure on social media platforms, which can lead to anxiety, depression, and other mental health issues. Social media often presents an idealized version of life, leading children to compare themselves to others. They are flooded with drawn up images of perfect bodies, lifestyles, and experiences, creating unrealistic standards that young individuals feel compelled to meet. This constant comparison can negatively affect self-esteem and contribute to feelings of inadequacy. Research indicates a strong correlation between the use of social media and body image issues, particularly among young girls. It pushed them into "rabbit holes of toxic and harmful content".

Moreover, features like "infinite scroll" are leading children to addiction and excessive use of social media. In an analysis by Common Sense, average daily screen use has increased from 4:44 to 5:33 among tweens, and up to 8:39 from 7:22 among teens in the past two years, leading to potential issues like sleep disturbances, reduced physical activity, and a negative impact on overall

well-being. It is obvious that young users are spending more time on social media platforms than engaging in traditional face-to-face interactions. Young users today find themselves easily immersed in a digital landscape that provides a unique approach for socialization. Traditionally, face-to-face interactions were the basis of socialization, developing our communication skills, empathy, and a sense of community. However, the rise of social media has redefined our culture, with virtual interactions becoming increasingly common. Because of that, young users would prefer to spend extended periods engaging with online communities rather than participating in real physical activities. According to recent research conducted in New York City, more than 38 percent of high school students expressed experiencing such profound sadness or hopelessness in the past year that they discontinued their usual activities. In 2021, the level of hopelessness among high school students in New York City was nearly 50 percent higher among Latino and Black students compared to white students. Additionally, it was almost 70 percent higher among female students than the male students.

TikTok, Snapchat, YouTube, and Meta, among other social media entities, are contributing to a widespread mental health crisis among the youth on a national scale. These companies prioritize financial gain over the welfare of children by purposefully incorporating manipulative and addictive features into their platforms. Social media platforms are carefully designed to capture and retain users' attention, which often lead to compulsive behaviors and addiction. Studies have shown that the constant stream of notifications, likes, and shares triggers the release of dopamine in the brain, creating a reward system that reinforces the desire to stay connected. It keeps consumers coming back over and over again. Currently, more than 33% of children aged 13 to 17 across the nation acknowledge being engaged with social media "almost constantly," and they recognize that this level of usage is excessive. However, over 50% of them express difficulties in reducing their social media consumption. The addictive nature of social media platforms raises big questions about the ethical

responsibility of these platforms and the potential consequences for the well-being of the younger generation. Also, unrestricted access to the internet exposes children to a wide range of content, not all of which is suitable for their age or maturity level. Last year, there was a case in Britain where a coroner ruled that Instagram had contributed to the death of a teenager named Molly. He said the internet has affected her in such a negative way that she took her own life after seeing thousands of images of self-harm on the platform. Exposure to explicit content, violence, or misinformation has created negative effects on their psychological development and perspectives. Even though the companies face no financial or other penalty because of the decision, the case was seen as a form of justice for the girl and to raise awareness about youth suicide and remind us of how dangerous social media is. After that, a draft law partly inspired by Molly's death was created to force social media companies to adopt new child safety protections. Apparently social media companies have failed in doing that because "nearly 100,000 children a day receive sexually explicit material or are targeted for sexual harassment". One important piece of evidence is from Torrez. His office used a social media account purportedly created by a 13-year-old girl as part of an undercover investigation on the sites. After using that account, he alleges that "certain child exploitative content" is 10 times more prevalent on social media platforms than it is on the porn site PornHub. The legal action contends that Meta's algorithms purportedly promote content related to sex and exploitation, while asserting that both Facebook and Instagram lack "effective" age verification measures. The lawsuit further alleges that the company did not successfully identify networks involved in child sexual exploitation and failed to completely prevent users previously suspended for such violations from rejoining the platform through new accounts. Even though Meta spokesperson mentioned that they have disabled more than half a million accounts for violating our child safety policies, they have not implemented enough changes to their platforms to effectively prevent the sexual exploitation of children while knowing that their

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products can inflict significant harm on young users. The ongoing lawsuits demand a thorough examination of content moderation policies to ensure the safety of young users. They contend that despite the companies portraying their platforms as secure for users, this representation is considered as "false and misleading," constituting a violation of the state's Deceptive Trade Practices Act. Additionally, the legal actions level accusations against the companies, including claims of negligence, product liability, and engaging in "unjust enrichment."

Children's online privacy is endangered seriously and they may not fully comprehend the implications of sharing personal information online. Some potential risks such as identity theft, stalking, or online exploitation might happen and it requires parental guidance and educational programs to empower children with the skills to navigate the internet responsibly. With that being said, social media companies are being accused of collecting "the personal data of its youngest users" without their parents' permission. Children often share personal information on social media platforms, gaming sites without knowing that they might lead to other consequences. In an article, the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) has highlighted instances where apps and websites targeting children have violated privacy laws by collecting and sharing personal information without parental consent. In that case, Microsoft has to pay $20 million to resolve allegations of violating the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA). The charges include accusations of collecting personal information from minors who registered for the Xbox gaming system without appropriately notifying their parents or obtaining parental consent. Additionally, Microsoft is accused of unlawfully retaining the personal information of these children. These reports emphasize the need for stricter regulations to protect children online. The violation of children's online privacy extends beyond isolated incidents. While social media has provided a global window of connectivity for countless individuals, significant social media corporations have misused their influence, leading to severe repercussions for the mental well-being of our younger

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generations. The responsible handling of personal data is necessary to recover trust between social media platforms, users, and their families.

Lastly, in the newest update, Mark Zuckerberg, Meta CEO, has officially apologized to families over social media harms in a contentious Senate hearing. All the parents of victims were there to listen and wanted an answer from Mark and other CEOs. Even though he did apologize, that was not enough and it only raised the tension between them. Instead, the apology has been met with skepticism, with some families labeling it as insincere and lacking deep genuine regret. Some of them even claimed that the apology they received was “fake” and “lacked any heart”. If nothing changes, the tension between the tech CEOs and affected families will remain tangible.

Overall, the rapid integration of social media into the lives of young users has started huge transformative changes, reshaping the entire social interaction. Despite providing constant connectivity and validation-seeking mechanisms, the digital era brings both opportunities and challenges. While online communities might offer unprecedented connectivity and exposure to diverse content, they also present unique challenges to mental well-being. Yet, the evolution of social interaction needs to be viewed from more perspectives rather than just from a lens of concern. The digital era introduces new opportunities for expression, connection, and exploration of diverse viewpoints. The challenge lies in balancing between the benefits of virtual connectivity and the value of face-to-face interactions. In order to achieve this balance, it requires intentional efforts, including educational lessons about how to use social media properly, healthy online behaviors, and the importance of offline socialization.

Finally, to control this continuously evolving technology, the responsibility falls on various people – from tech CEOs to parents, educators, and the users themselves. I agree that parents have to teach their children what they should do and what they should not, but in a world where we can see technologies everywhere, they cannot control everything. There are a lot of unexpected things

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on the internet. Children have to go to school, go hang out and play with their friends. How can we restrict that too? So the first action needs to come from the companies that are responsible for this. Beyond the fact that social media platforms are paid to display advertisements, it is crucial to address the concerning impact these advertising practices can have, particularly on the younger generations. As these platforms target a wide audience, their influence on the mental health and well-being of young users cannot be ignored. All recent lawsuits against popular figures in the tech industry have underscored the need for accountability, transparency, and a commitment to minimizing the negative impacts of social media on young users. The tension between affected families and the CEOs has also reflected a broader societal conversation about how we can ensure the well-being of the younger generation while maintaining the benefits of digital connectivity. As we conclude this exploration, it is essential to recognize that the digital era is not just a powerful force, but also a dynamic landscape that demands adaptability and responsible navigation.

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Citations:

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show where we are going

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